contributions, ensuring that the organization's role is visible and recognized (Dietrich, Hyde, and Winters 2019; Oliveros, Weltz-Shapiro, and Winters 2023). These efforts help raise awareness of IO activities and foster goodwill among local communities.

Critics, however, argue that foreign aid can undermine confidence in domestic governments, as citizens may view them as unable to provide essential services (Knack 2001; Dietrich and Winters 2015). Furthermore, targeting aid toward populations aligned with populist leaders may provoke resentment from other groups, reducing the net benefit of such initiatives. The effects of branding and aid provision can also be limited, with some studies finding only marginal improvements in public perceptions (Dietrich, Mahmud, and Winters 2018; Blair, Marty, and Roessler 2022).

Another limitation is that not all IOs are equipped to provide direct benefits. Judicial bodies or institutions with constrained budgets may lack the capacity to engage in large-scale aid distribution. Others may face resistance from influential member states, limiting their ability to target resources effectively. Thus, while providing goods and services is a valuable tool, it is not universally doable and can be costly.

7.1.2 Rolling Back Constraints

Another method for reducing populist resistance is scaling back the constraints that IOs impose on member states and their populations. Populists often frame IOs as overreaching institutions that infringe on sovereignty, making it politically costly for leaders to comply with their mandates. By easing these constraints, IOs can reduce public hostility and maintain engagement.

This approach can take several forms. IOs might refrain from calling out rule violations when doing so could anger domestic audiences, delay sanctions to avoid backlash, or strategically time public criticism to minimize its impact. For instance, international courts sometimes practice judicial economy, declining to rule on contentious cases that could fuel populist narratives (Voeten 2020).

While selective leniency can help mitigate populist opposition, it comes with its own risks. Favoring some states over others can create perceptions of bias, undermining the fairness and legitimacy of IOs (Stone 2011).